README – Tombstone

Title: Tombstone
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Engine: Twine (Harlowe)

Spoiler Warning

This README contains story spoilers, including the narrative structure, key plot revelations, and all possible endings.

Game Overview

Tombstone is an interactive narrative game built in Twine. The story follows Marcus Vale, an inmate serving a life sentence in Tombstone Penitentiary. What begins as a normal prison morning turns into a violent confrontation that forces Marcus to relive a traumatic event from his past. Through a combination of present choices and a dreamlike flashback sequence, the player is asked to navigate guilt, memory, violence, and choose to expose the truth or to withhold it. The game is designed as a short narrative experience with multiple endings, including a hidden ending.

How to Play

The game is played by clicking the linked text choices in each passage. Some choices provide alternate dialogue or emotional responses, while others directly influence the path of the story and determine the ending. The game is intended to take approximately 5 to 10 minutes to complete (depending how fast you can read).

Story Summary

The game is divided into three acts:

Act 1: A Normal Day in Paradise:
introduces Marcus, the prison environment, and the arrival of a mysterious young inmate. The act escalates into a violent confrontation in the yard that results in Jay's death and Marcus losing consciousness.

Act 2: There's No Place Like Home

is a dreamlike flashback sequence. Marcus relives a traumatic event from fifteen years earlier, when he witnessed a mugging, tried to intervene, and contributed to the deaths of a man and woman while their child watched.

Act 3: The Things We Bury
takes place in the prison med ward, where Marcus wakes chained to a bed and is confronted by the now-grown boy from the alley. The final conversation forces Marcus to either confess the truth or deny responsibility.

Walkthrough

One possible run through the game is:

1. Marcus wakes in his prison cell and investigates the morning commotion. You don't choose to mess with anything and proceed to the window.

2. He joins Jay and Moe in the yard.

3. A fight breaks out involving the new inmate.

4. You choose to refrain from fighting, but your friend unintentionally dies during the violence. You choose to succumb to pure rage and violently attack the killer. He's then knocked out by prison guards

5. Marcus blacks out and enters a dreamlike flashback. The flashback unveils the truth to why he's at Tombstone and what's so important about the mysterious new visitor. It also peeks into the mental state of the main character.

6. In the med ward, Marcus is confronted by the stranger. You have to have a difficult conversation with him, as the stranger appears to be unstable by the sight of you.

7. The player chooses whether Marcus confesses or denies the truth, leading to one of the main endings.

Endings

Ending 1: Acceptance / Confession
Marcus admits his role in the deaths from the alley. The confrontation ends without forgiveness, but with an honest and painful acknowledgment that the past cannot be undone.

Ending 2: Denial
Marcus refuses to admit the truth. The surviving boy leaves in disappointment and anger, condemning Marcus not only for the past, but also for refusing honesty in the present.

Secret Ending: The Baby Ending
A hidden joke ending can be triggered through repeated interaction with the mirror at the beginning of the game. This ending serves as an Easter egg and contrasts with the otherwise dark tone of the story (kind of wanted to mimic the ridiculousness of the Dog ending from *Silent Hill 2*).

All writing, characters, and narrative structure were created as original work for this project, with some tonal inspiration drawn from popular media such as Silent Hill and Batman. No external images, sounds, or copyrighted media were used in the final project.